

Shavkat Khamraev, Minister of Water Resources of the Republic of Uzbekistan, Honored Irrigator of Uzbekistan

“There is no alternative to addressing the water challenge other than taking into account the interests of all countries and peoples of the region.”

Shavkat Mirziyoyev

For centuries, life in Central Asia has been inseparable from water. Across the Amu Darya and Syr Darya basins, settlements, agriculture and trade developed around rivers, canals and irrigation systems. Water has therefore never been merely a natural resource for the region; it has been one of the foundations of its economic life, social stability and shared history.

Today, the water challenge is more pressing than ever. Climate change, population and economic growth, shrinking glaciers, droughts and increasingly frequent extreme weather events are placing mounting pressure on water resources. One conclusion is clear: no single country can ensure water security in Central Asia on its own. The only sustainable path lies in cooperation, mutual trust, accurate measurement and shared responsibility.

One River Basin, Shared Interests

Central Asia's major rivers originate in some countries and flow through others. The Syr Darya is vital to Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan, while the Amu Darya is equally significant for Tajikistan, Afghanistan, Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan.

This geographical reality makes it essential to avoid framing the interests of upstream and downstream countries as inherently opposed. For one state, water may be a key source of hydropower; for another, it is indispensable for irrigated agriculture. At the same time, preserving river ecosystems, improving the environmental situation in the Aral Sea region and ensuring access to water security and access to safe drinking water are common priorities for all countries.

Around 90 per cent of water in Central Asia is used in agriculture. Water management therefore cannot be shaped solely around the interests of one sector or one country. What is needed is a regional approach that recognises the close interdependence of water, energy, food security and the environment.

Open Dialogue, Practical Results

In recent years, dialogue among the countries of Central Asia has become more open and constructive. This has had a direct impact on cooperation in the water sector. Whereas discussions once focused primarily on seasonal water allocation, the agenda today is considerably broader, encompassing water-energy cooperation, joint management of shared facilities, digitalisation, improved water accounting, scientific collaboration and professional training.

At the Seventh Consultative Meeting of the Heads of State of Central Asia, held in Tashkent in November 2025, the President of Uzbekistan drew attention to growing water scarcity and proposed declaring 2026–2036 the "Decade of Practical Action for the Rational Use of Water in Central Asia". The establishment of a Regional Competence Centre for Water Management at the Tashkent Institute of Irrigation and

Agricultural Mechanization Engineers National Research University was also proposed.

At the summit of the International Fund for Saving the Aral Sea in April 2026, the President of Uzbekistan outlined priority tasks for the country's chairmanship of the Fund in 2027–2029. These include improving the Fund's organisational and legal mechanisms, increasing the effectiveness of programmes in the Aral Sea basin, attracting international financing, promoting a culture of responsible water use and strengthening professional capacity in the sector.

Agreements as a Practical Basis of Cooperation

Regional dialogue produces lasting results only when it is backed by concrete agreements and practical cooperation.

On 15 November 2025, Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan signed an Agreement on the Joint Management and Rational Use of Transboundary Water Bodies. The agreement is designed to establish systematic cooperation between the two countries in the water sector, improve coordination among responsible agencies and ensure more effective use of shared water resources and infrastructure.

With the Kyrgyz Republic, issues related to water use, the operation of hydraulic structures and water distribution during the irrigation season are regularly addressed through joint mechanisms. On 15 May 2026, the eighth meeting of the Uzbek-Kyrgyz Joint Commission on Water Management was held in Namangan. In June, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan also agreed on water release volumes and electricity supplies for the 2026 irrigation season.

Within the framework of the joint Working Group with Tajikistan, the parties regularly discuss transboundary water-management projects, exchange experience in managing water resources and address other practical matters.

Uzbekistan, Tajikistan and Kazakhstan also cooperate in coordinating the summer operating regime of the Bahri Tojik Reservoir. The operating regime is agreed annually at working-level meetings involving representatives of the three countries and is formalised through the relevant protocols.

A joint intergovernmental commission on water issues operates between Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan. Cooperation covers water-saving technologies, the reconstruction of collector-drainage networks, scientific exchange and professional training in irrigation. In 2025, for example, the second stage of the reconstruction of the Ozyorny and Daryolik main collectors in Turkmenistan was completed.

These examples demonstrate an important shift: water cooperation in Central Asia is moving beyond general declarations towards concrete mechanisms — commissions, agreements, technical projects and water-energy exchanges.

Reliable Data as a Foundation of Trust

In water relations, trust is built not only through political declarations but also through accurate and transparent data.

How much water is flowing through a river? What volumes are stored in reservoirs? How much water has been released, how much has reached users and how much has been lost along the way? These questions must be answered on the basis of reliable information that all parties can trust.

This is why it is increasingly important to automate transboundary hydrological monitoring stations, enable remote data transmission, introduce digital water accounting and harmonise information-exchange systems among countries.

In July 2026, the World Bank approved the Regional Cooperation Project to Improve the Efficiency of Water Resources Use in Central Asian Countries (CAWEC), aimed at

strengthening transboundary water cooperation in the region.

The project envisages a US$20 million grant to the Executive Committee of the International Fund for Saving the Aral Sea. The funds are intended to support the digitalisation of water accounting in the Amu Darya and Syr Darya basins, modernise information systems and strengthen the professional capacity of specialists.

By 2031, the project is also expected to support the preparation of mutually beneficial transboundary investment projects involving at least two Central Asian countries, including preliminary feasibility studies, design and cost documentation, and environmental and social assessments.

It is expected that around 40 million people will benefit directly or indirectly from the project's results.

Water Conservation in Uzbekistan Also Serves Regional Interests

The rational use of transboundary water resources begins with the responsibility of each country to use water efficiently within its own territory.

In 2017, water-saving technologies were applied on 28,000 hectares in Uzbekistan. By the end of 2025, this figure had reached 2.6 million hectares — nearly 60 per cent of the country's irrigated land. Since the beginning of 2026, water-saving technologies have been introduced on a further 640,000 hectares.

Around 174,000 kilometres of irrigation networks are used to supply water to 4.3 million hectares of irrigated land in Uzbekistan. Public funding for modernising this extensive system, reducing water losses in canals and improving efficiency has increased steadily. In 2017, 842 billion soums were allocated to irrigation and land-reclamation works; in 2020, the figure rose to 1.7 trillion soums, and in 2025 to 3 trillion soums.

In 2026, 4.1 trillion soums were allocated from the state budget for irrigation and land-reclamation facilities — 4.9 times higher than the 2017 level.

By the end of 2026, Uzbekistan plans to save 11 billion cubic metres of water through the wider use of water-saving technologies, laser land levelling, the repair and concrete lining of irrigation networks, digitalisation, optimisation of crop patterns and improved agricultural practices. Under the state programme for 2025–2028, this figure is expected to rise to 12 billion cubic metres in 2027 and 13 billion cubic metres in 2028.

These figures matter not only for Uzbekistan, but for the region as a whole. Every cubic metre of water saved in one country reduces pressure on the shared river basin. Water conservation is therefore not merely a national objective; it is also a practical expression of good-neighbourly responsibility.

Five Pillars for the Future

Five areas are particularly important if Central Asia is to take water cooperation to a new level.

First, interstate cooperation mechanisms need to be adapted to contemporary realities. Clear legal arrangements are required for water allocation, the use of shared infrastructure and the exchange of information.

Second, water accounting should be further digitalised, with timely exchange of data on water availability and flows. Reliable information is the foundation of reliable cooperation.

Third, the region needs more joint investment projects to modernise ageing canals, hydraulic structures, pumping stations and water-metering facilities. The

uninterrupted operation of a single facility in one country may directly serve the interests of several neighbouring states.

Fourth, water and energy issues should be addressed in an integrated manner. Better coordination of reservoir operating regimes, electricity supplies and seasonal water needs can significantly improve the efficiency of resource use.

Fifth, greater attention must be paid to science, human capital and a culture of responsible water use. Modern technologies alone are not enough. They require skilled specialists, farmers who have a clear incentive to conserve water, and a society that understands the true value of this resource.

Water conservation is not the responsibility of water professionals alone. It is also a matter of economic thinking, environmental responsibility and everyday culture.

Water as a Shared Responsibility for a Common Future

The history of Central Asia shows that water has not only sustained communities; it has also connected them. Villages, cities, markets and cultural ties developed along rivers, canals and irrigation channels. Preserving that unifying role of water is just as important today.

In the twenty-first century, effective water management is determined not only by how much water is available. It also depends on the quality of cooperation between countries, the efficiency with which water is used, and the accuracy with which it is measured and accounted for.

The challenges ahead are substantial. Demand for water is rising, the climate is changing and economies are expanding. Yet Central Asia has also developed a stronger culture of cooperation. Regular dialogue among heads of state, bilateral and

multilateral agreements, modern technologies and support from international partners are creating practical opportunities to address shared challenges together.

Joint efforts to conserve water contribute to peace and stability. Rational use of this vital resource is an investment in economic development. Above all, it is an investment in a more prosperous, resilient and sustainable future for the entire region. ///nCa, 4 October 2026 (in cooperation with the Embassy of Uzbekistan to Turkmenistan)

Filed Under: Articles And Reports

2026 – Независимый нейтральный Туркменистан – родина целеустремлённых крылатых скакунов

